
Discursive Strategies in Selected News Stories of GERD

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Abstract

This research paper investigates the discursive strategies proposed by van Dijk (2006) and Ruth Wodak (2005) in a selection of published online news stories on the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD). The news stories handled here comprise many interesting instances of discursive strategies which functionally orient the readers' mental cognitions. There is a sort of categorization in the discourse of each news story as per the two conflicting parties representing Ethiopia versus Egypt/Sudan. It is mainly through argumentation/legitimization that each party seeks to gain the support of others by constantly justifying its actions. The conflict revolves around the Nile water and what impact can the GERD have on the water shortage for both Egypt and Sudan. The other discursive strategies deployed include labelling/referential nomination, use of numbers, and generalization/depersonalization.

This paper suggests the awareness of the text producer of such discursive strategies while reporting the news stories under investigation. This leads to the possibility of the news agency to own a certain aimed ideology that should be prevailing and nurturing ideas for different audiences. The selected news stories belong to various online platforms such as: Daily News of Egypt, Addis Standard, Al-Monitor, The National News, The New Arab, etc. Investigating such various platforms help reveal the underlying discursive strategies and their communicative functions in text.

Keywords: *online news stories on GERD, argumentation/legitimization, labelling/referential nomination, use of numbers, and generalization/depersonalization.*

Introduction

According to Carnegie Middle East Center, the Egyptian-Ethiopian Nile River dispute has its origins in the Anglo-Egyptian Treaty of 1929. The Ethiopians were not party to the accord, which the United Kingdom purported to negotiate with Egypt on behalf of Ethiopia and several other Nile Basin countries where the British held sway. In April 2011, when Ethiopia launched the GERD project, it consulted neither Egypt nor Sudan, maintaining that the matter was an open-and-shut case of Ethiopian sovereignty. Egyptian authorities knew full well that the Blue Nile, on whose riverbank the GERD was being built, is the main source of the Nile and therefore provides much of the water upon which the country relies so heavily. Therefore, Addis Ababa's actions set off alarm bells in Cairo. To make matters worse, Ethiopia stalled on allowing an environmental and social impact assessment (ESIA) of the dam, which is required under international law for projects of this kind. Again, the Ethiopians maintained that the issue was one of sovereignty.

From the Egyptian perspective, now that the country has accepted the inevitability of the dam going operational, an ESIA is crucial to addressing its technical concerns. Among these concerns is that the initial filling of the GERD's reservoir does not proceed too quickly. The Egyptian government is insisting on a slow fill of twelve to twenty-one years to prevent major challenges to Egypt's water security, but the Ethiopian government insists on completing the process within six years in order to increase its capacity to generate power, a major preoccupation as more than half of Ethiopia's population has no access to electricity. Additionally, given that Egypt expects to face water scarcity as soon as 2025, the Egyptian government wants to ensure that downstream river flow is not affected by Ethiopia's refilling of the reservoir during periods of prolonged drought, when the Blue Nile's water level recedes due to lack of rainfall.

The latest of ten rounds of negotiations stretching over five years had taken place in Washington, D.C. under the aegis of both former U.S. president Donald Trump's administration and the World Bank. From this negotiating marathon was born a proposal. When it came to signing it, however, Ethiopia backed out over concerns that its provisions would infringe upon the country's sovereignty. A few months later, the Ethiopian government reiterated its intention to begin filling the dam's reservoir in July. Egypt, which considered such a unilateral move to be in contravention of the DoP (Declaration of Principles), immediately called on the UN Security Council to condemn it.

Methods of analysis

Since language is the primary means of reporting, van Dijk (2006) considers discursive strategies as macro-ideological strategies to either enhance or mitigate our/their bad characteristics and, as a result, mark discourse ideologically. Van Dijk (2006) goes further to propose some of the discursive strategies for realizing positive self-representation and negative other representation as actor description, categorization, euphemism, evidentiality, example/illustration, generalization, hyperbole, lexicalization, metaphor, self-glorification, number game, polarization, presupposition, and victimization. These strategies are utilized in news reports to construct polarity as well as social inequality and bias.

Other discursive strategies proposed by Wodak (2005) include:

- Referential nomination: comprises referring expressions and description of actors which show the position of the interactants.
- Prediction: refers to the intention of speakers to describe social actors negatively and positively with the use of metaphors.
- Argumentation: reveals the moments when speakers attempt to legitimize or justify negative or positive acts they produce.
- Perspectivization and re-perspectivization: describes a speaker's attempt to involve his audience through a variety of techniques such as reporting, describing, narrating, or quoting.

- Intensification: occurs when the speaker produces utterances implicitly or explicitly.

The analysis of the selected news stories draws on the proposed discursive strategies by both van Dijk (2006) and Wodak (2005).

Data Analysis

This section provides an analysis of the deployed discursive strategies in the selected news stories of GERD.

1. Generalization/depersonalization strategy

As a discursive strategy in reporting news stories, depersonalization strategy is employed to mystify or hide the referent who has started the action. For instance, there are depersonalized expressions used in the investigated examples as follows:

“The AU’s interventions in the GERD crisis added nothing to the table.”

(Daily News Egypt.)

“It is regrettable to witness that the progress of the negotiations has been dragged and politicized/ The process has also revealed there longstanding challenges which have to do with the absence of water treaty and basin-wide mechanism on the Nile.” (Addis Standard.)

“Details of Mr. Blinken’s talks with Ethiopian leaders on the Dam issue were not disclosed/ a major challenge is the presence of troops from neighboring Eritrea/ Terrorist attacks have more than doubled in sub-Saharan Africa since 2016.” (The National News.)

“The new development comes after Cairo issued a fresh warning/ Such a threat constitutes a flagrant breach of The United Nations Charter and Constitutive Act of the African Union/ An amicable solution between the three countries is within reach/ The accusation comes after the 22-member League passed a resolution.” (Monitor.)

“Tensions dramatically escalated between Ethiopia and Egypt/ Negotiations between Egypt and Ethiopia broke down in March/ The new Ethiopian unilateralism concerning the dam stands in sharp contrast to previous agreements/ The deployment of missiles is expected to be completed in June.” (The New Arab.)

“Negotiations between the three countries have been frozen since April 2021/ Satellite images showed Ethiopian preparations to start the fourth filling of the GERD.” (Aawsat.)

“Egypt’s water resources have become unable to meet the needs of its population/ Negotiations over the dam between Egypt, Ethiopia and Sudan have stalled for years.” (Egypt Independent.)

“The water level in the GERD lake had crossed last year’s level/ The third stage will likely raise more tensions with the downstream countries/ Negotiations between Egypt, Sudan, and Ethiopia are still stumbling/ The damage ensuing from the third filling is likely to be contained/ Any unilateral step without mutual consent will stir more escalation and tensions, a compromise is needed now more than ever.” (Al-Monitor.)

The above excerpts are taken from different news stories published in various online platforms. The generalization/depersonalization strategy is achieved here through the use of generally oriented statements, nominalization, inanimate actors, and passive structure. For instance, the generally oriented statements include *“It is regrettable to witness that the progress of the negotiations has been dragged and politicized/ a major challenge is the presence of troops from neighboring Eritrea/ Terrorist attacks have more than doubled in sub-Saharan Africa since 2016”*. In these statements, there is a general orientation towards some facts accompanied by a sense of neglecting the main actors or causes for the resulting consequences.

Turning to the nominalized statements which include *“Details of Mr. Blinken’s talks with Ethiopian leaders on the Dam issue were not disclosed/ An amicable solution between the three countries is within reach/ The new*

Ethiopian unilateralism concerning the dam stands in sharp contrast to previous agreements/ The damage ensuing from the third filling is likely to be contained/ Any unilateral step without mutual consent will stir more escalation and tensions, a compromise is needed now more than ever,” it can be noticed that there is not a direct actor to hold responsible for the actions, instead, there is a nominalized structure followed by a descriptive attribute, then by a verb to give a complete sentence. Again, the use of nominalization provides an attention to a certain idea without any inclusion of specific actors.

The use of inanimate actors is yet another way of delivering a generalization/depersonalization strategy through assigning the role of an agent to an inanimate actor. These include *“The process has also revealed there longstanding challenges which have to do with the absence of water treaty and basin-wide mechanism on the Nile/ The AU’s interventions in the GERD crisis added nothing to the table/ Such a threat constitutes a flagrant breach of The United Nations Charter and Constitutive Act of the African Union/ The accusation comes after the 22-member League passed a resolution/ Tensions dramatically escalated between Ethiopia and Egypt/ Negotiations between Egypt and Ethiopia broke down in March/ Negotiations between the three countries have been frozen since April 2021/ Negotiations over the dam between Egypt, Ethiopia and Sudan have stalled for years/ Negotiations between Egypt, Sudan, and Ethiopia are still stumbling/ The third stage will likely raise more tensions with the downstream countries/ The water level in the GERD lake had crossed last year’s level/ Satellite images showed Ethiopian preparations to start the fourth filling of the GERD”*.

Lastly, the use of the passive helps the text producer to achieve such a depersonalization strategy as in *“The deployment of missiles is expected to be completed in June”*. There is no agent mentioned due to the use of the passive structure.

2. Number Game

Using numbers in a news story is seen as a discursive strategy to promote credibility and reliability in the news outlet in the investigated

examples and there is a regular use of numbers throughout. This can be manifested through the excerpts below:

“\$331 million in new humanitarian aid/ reconstruction bill of \$20 billion/ in sub-Saharan Africa since 2016.” (The National News.)

“Signed on 23 March 2015/ on the project in 2011/ the 22-member League.” (Monitor.)

“The 2015 Declaration of Principles/ letter from Ethiopia on July 26.” (SIS)

“55.5 billion cubic meters/ 90 percent of its supply/ frozen since April 2021/ on August 11.” (Aawsat.)

“88% of the construction/ by the end of 2023/ 60-70 million m³/day/ 590 meters above sea level/ 4 billion m³/ a level of 595 meters/ storage of 5.5 billion m³/ in mid-September 2021/ 8 billion cubic meters/ in a July 13 Facebook post.” (Al-Monitor.)

The use of numbers helps the text producer create a more realistic view of the information provided. For example, the excerpts above give details about amounts of money, space measurements, percents, and dates of documented events. The use of numbers orients the readers to grasp an imagination of possible amounts, possible spaces, and major events documented by dates, months, and years.

3. Referential nomination/labelling

Different labels are being bestowed upon either Ethiopia or Egypt and Sudan in the investigated examples. These labels help the reader assign different roles to the intended referents each time. The following excerpts below illustrate this aspect.

“Others/ downstream countries/ Egypt and Sudan vs. Prime Minister/members of the House of Peoples’ Representatives (HPR)/we.” (ENA.)

“Egypt/ Egyptian Foreign Minister/ Cairo and Khartoum/ the Arab League/the downstream countries vs. Ethiopia/ Addis Ababa/ the Ethiopian Ministry of Foreign Affairs/ riparian countries.” (Monitor.)

“Egypt/ foreign minister/ downstream countries/ the Egyptian state/ the Egyptian people vs. Upstream country/ Ethiopia/ Addis Ababa.” (SIS.)

“Egypt/ President Abdel Fattah al-Sisi/ Defense Minister/ other military chiefs/ Egyptian armed forces/ Egyptian officials vs. Ethiopia/ Addis Ababa/ Ethiopian news agency/ foreign ministry spokesman.” (The New Arab.)

The labels used in these excerpts report the news story through mentioning the country, its capital, or their location as per the Nile River. Sometimes, there are references to the official figures in those countries such as *“foreign minister/Egyptian armed forces/Egyptian officials/the Arab League vs. House of Peoples’ representatives/we”*. The different roles assigned deliver diverse perspectives on what is stated in accordance with the represented agents, their actions, and stances.

4. Argumentation/legitimization

Legitimization is another discursive strategy that aims at justifying the actions of different participants and making them appear both legitimate and justifiable in the presented context. The following excerpts below illustrate this aspect.

“Ethiopia’s interest is just to address the country’s demand of electricity/ To reduce concerns of Sudan and Egypt as well as bring a lasting peace and prosperity for our region.” (ENA.)

“Sudan’s Minister of Foreign Affairs Maryam Al-Sadiq Al-Mahdi has demanded the international community to impose sanctions on Ethiopia for its intransigence regarding its controversial dam.” (Daily News Egypt.)

“Egypt and Sudan have been in talks with Ethiopia to reach an agreement on the filling and operation of the Grand Ethiopian

Renaissance Dam (GERD)/ A deal to end the Tigray conflict before normalizing relations/ Visiting Ethiopia to repair relations that were strained by the two-year war in the northern region/ Out of concern for massacres, gang rapes and other abuses committed by all sides in the fighting, the US imposed sanctions and restricted economic support to Ethiopia.” (The National News.)

“His country will continue to interact with all countries to resolve the water dispute/ They insist Ethiopia halts water-filling operations until the parties reach a legally binding agreement.” (Monitor.)

“Egypt registers objection to UNSC against Ethiopia to unilaterally continue filling GERD/ Egypt renewed demand for Ethiopia to comply with the rules of international law and principles governing transnational waterways.” (SIS.)

“Addis Ababa refused to sign a US-drafted agreement regulating the filling of the dam, saying that it was entitled to fill it at its own pace/ Both Egypt and Sudan have expressed strong opposition to Ethiopia unilaterally filling the dam without agreement/ Ethiopia was under no obligation to notify either Egypt or Sudan about when the dam would be filled/ Egypt indicated that it was prepared to take military action to secure its supply of Nile water.” (The New Arab.)

“Egypt fears the GERD would damage its limited share of the Nile water/ Egypt has been in futile negotiations for more than a decade with Ethiopia and Sudan in an attempt to reach an agreement/ Then negotiation stumbled due to Ethiopia's procrastination in reaching a binding legal framework for filling and operating the dam/ Egypt resorted to the UN Security Council to protect and demand pressure on Ethiopia through international partners to accept an agreement that satisfies all parties/ The diplomat called for international intervention to solve the issue.” (Aawsat.)

The excerpts above show Ethiopia's determination on filling the dam and this determination is justified by the fact of addressing “the country's

demand of electricity/to bring a lasting peace and prosperity to our region/it was entitled to fill it at its own pace/Ethiopia was under no obligation to notify Egypt or Sudan about when the dam would be filled.” For Egypt and Sudan, on the other hand, their actions are justified by the fact that *“the GERD would damage its limited share of the Nile water/ Egypt registers objection to UNSC against Ethiopia to unilaterally continue filling GERD/ They insist Ethiopia halts water-filling operations until the parties reach a legally binding agreement/ Egypt renewed demand for Ethiopia to comply with the rules of international law and principles governing transnational waterways.”* Finally, Mr. Blinken’s visit to Ethiopia is further justified by the need *“to repair relations that were strained by the two-year war in the northern region”* and sanctions imposed by the US are justified *“Out of concern for massacres, gang rapes and other abuses committed by all sides in the fighting, the US imposed sanctions and restricted economic support to Ethiopia.”* Consequently, the use of argumentation as a discursive strategy is prevailing to point out the contradictory stances of each party and provide a clear justification for their actions.

Conclusion

This paper has shed light on some of the deployed discursive strategies in the published online news stories on GERD. The news story usually portrays two conflicting parties representing Ethiopia versus Egypt/Sudan. The discursive strategies detected include generalization/depersonalization, labelling/referential nomination, number game and argumentation/legitimization. These strategies show an awareness of the text producer towards orienting his readers to embrace a certain perspective. The discursive strategies work together to communicate some cognitively loaded details about the represented parties. Consequently, discursive strategies are of utmost importance for journalists and reporters.

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استراتيجيات الخطاب في مجموعة مختارة من القصص الإخبارية عن سد النهضة الإثيوبي

ملخص

يتناول هذا البحث استراتيجيات الخطاب التي اقترحها كل من فان ديجك (2006)، وروث وداك (2005) في مجموعة مختارة من القصص الإخبارية عن سد النهضة الإثيوبي. حيث تحتوي هذه القصص الإخبارية على عدة أمثلة لاستراتيجيات الخطاب التي تؤثر على التوجه الفكري للقراء. يُعتبر التصنيف عامل أساسي في جميع القصص الإخبارية، حيث أنها تتضمن طرفين متصارعين- إثيوبيا ضد مصر والسودان- حول مياه النيل وتأثير سد النهضة الإثيوبي على حصة البلدين من المياه. ويسعى الطرفان إلى توضيح القضية كل من منظوره وهو ما ينطوي على عدة استراتيجيات هامة تتطلب الدراسة.

ومن ضمن استراتيجيات الخطاب التي استخدمها محرر النص الحجة/الشرعية والتي يستخدمها أحد طرفي النزاع أو كليهما لتقديم المبررات عن أفعالهم والفوز بتأييد القاريء. ويليهِ التأثير المرجعي/التلقيب الذي يسبغ عدة ألقاب على طرفي النزاع يمكن تتبعها عبر الخبر. ثم يرد استخدام الأرقام الي تشير إلى تاريخ أو عام أو قياسات، وأخيراً ترد استراتيجية التعميم التي تنقل الأحداث دون الإشارة المباشرة إلى الفاعل. ويقترح هذا البحث إمام الكاتب بتلك الاستراتيجيات حيث أنها تعينه على توجيه القاريء نحو تبني إيدولوجية بعينها. كما تأتي الأخبار من عدة مصادر إخبارية متنوعة منها دايلي نيوز أوف إيجبت، وأديس ستاندرد، والمونيتور، وناشونال نيوز، وذا نيو آراب، حيث يهدف تحليل تلك الاستراتيجيات إلى معرفة الوظيفة التواصلية لكل منها.

الكلمات المفتاحية: القصص الإخبارية عن سد النهضة ، الحجة/الشرعية، التأثير المرجعي/التلقيب، الأرقام، التعميم.